

A platform for European wetland restoration projects

Concept note for the development partner · 22 September 2026

1. The short version

We want to build a website where our European wetland restoration projects are presented in enough depth that a large company or an investor can judge them, get in touch privately, agree a deal, and where every step of that deal is recorded permanently.

Think of it as a cross between a property listing site and a deal room, for a product most people have never bought before.

2. The background you need

Companies are under growing pressure, from regulators and from their own risk, to do something measurable about nature. Some of them are also directly exposed: a power station needs water in the river, a drinks company needs water in the catchments around its production sites. Restoring a wetland upstream helps both.

A **biodiversity credit** is a way of packaging that restoration so it can be sold. A project restores a wetland, an independent body verifies the ecological result, and the result is issued as units the buyer can purchase and then retire, meaning take out of circulation so nobody else can claim it. The market is new and small. There is no single standard, and different schemes measure different things.

Three consequences shape this build:

Credits are issued later. Our pilot projects have their project idea notes and project design documents in place. Credits are issued only after an independent body has verified the results on the ground, which comes later. So most of what gets agreed on this platform is a commitment to future units, not a sale of something sitting in inventory. The platform has to handle deals on units that will exist later.

Units from different projects are not interchangeable. One project may sell hectares under restoration for a year, another may sell points on an index. Adding them together produces a meaningless number. The platform must never do it.

We are not the registry. Each credit scheme runs its own official database of issued and retired units, and does not give outside systems write access. So we store references to their records

plus the supporting documents. Our own record is evidence of what was agreed, not the authoritative record of what exists.

Sylva runs this platform as part of an EU-funded pilot. That matters to you in two ways: every page must carry the EU emblem and the line "Co-funded by the European Union" with a short disclaimer, and everything is hosted in the EU. More on that in section 9.

3. What we learned from the buyers

We interviewed eight organisations between June and September: two water-dependent corporates, two large companies with sustainability reporting obligations, three banks and funds, and a foundation. Four points shape the design.

Location matters most to the water-dependent companies and to the reporting companies. The water-dependent companies want a project in the same catchment as their own sites; a catchment is the area of land that drains into a particular river or aquifer. The reporting companies want projects near their own assets. European origin as such did not matter to them.

The water-dependent companies rank water outcomes first and biodiversity second. They would claim the biodiversity benefit, but water is what they are paying for.

Who gets to claim what can decide whether a buyer takes part. One company said it would not fund a project if the onward sale of credits took away its right to claim the benefit it had paid for, and compared this to power purchase agreements that sign away the renewable attributes. Another does not want its investment used by others as an offset.

Participation is anonymous by default, and naming is the buyer's choice, deal by deal. Two of the organisations we interviewed supported this directly.

4. Who uses it

Project owners. The organisations that run the restoration. They put projects on the platform and answer questions.

Buyers. Large companies, in two groups that want different things from the same page: the water-driven buyer wants catchment and hydrology, the reporting-driven buyer wants documentation its auditor will accept.

Investors. Funds and banks. They finance the project and are repaid from credit sales and other revenue. They need financial data, and they come in once buyers have committed.

Us, the operator. Sylva. We vet everyone who wants to transact, confirm records and publish.

Auditors. Read-only access to everything including real names, for the funder and external auditors.

5. What can be transacted

Three deal shapes, offered side by side on each project, because the buyers we spoke to differ on this:

A **spot volume**, where units already exist and the buyer takes some and retires them when ready.

A **forward contract**, where the buyer commits now to take a volume in a future year at agreed terms. Most of our pilot deals will take this form, because credits are issued later.

A **co-investment**, where a company funds a share of the project directly and the volume it does not need is sold to other buyers.

6. The project page

This is the heart of the product. Every project gets its own page at its own URL, shareable and indexable, so buyers can forward it to colleagues.

We have no photographs or video of the projects yet and are not waiting for them. The buyers asked for the following, and most of it can be filled from the project idea notes and design documents we already hold:

The catchment view. The project boundary and the surrounding catchment on a satellite map. If the visitor has registered their own sites, show the distance from those sites to the project. Boundaries are GeoJSON; the file should be downloadable.

Claim rights. For each benefit the project produces, a plain statement of who may claim it, for what, and what is excluded.

Outcomes. What is measured, water indicators and the biodiversity metric, with the baseline, the monitoring plan, the verifier and the stated uncertainty.

Durability. What happens to the site after the contract ends: who controls the land, who has committed to maintain it, for how long. One buyer asked about the period after a five-year contract, another about thirty to forty years.

A reporting evidence pack. European companies report on nature under a regime called CSRD. One reporting company told us its assessor asked it to consider projects with a measurable action, a fixed timeframe, expected impact, a budget and a verification standard.

We assemble exactly that as a downloadable pack. We state what is in it and make no claim that it satisfies any particular auditor.

The partners on the ground. Who develops the project, who owns the land, who verifies. One buyer told us it judges a project by meeting the people behind it.

Availability. How many units the project expects to issue in each period, how much is already committed, how much is left. Held back from that is a buffer, a margin of unsold units in case the project delivers less than expected. Per period, per project, never totalled across projects.

Documents. Project idea note, project design document, monitoring plan and, later, verification reports.

Investor data. Financing need, revenue streams, the financial model. Visible only to investors we have vetted.

Plus a private question box. Questions go to the project owner and to us, not to a public comment feed.

7. The private side

A buyer clicks one button, Express interest. That opens a private room between that buyer and that project: messages, documents, versions of the draft terms, and a stage marker running from first interest, through a letter of intent and a term sheet, to signed.

Agreements are signed outside the platform, and the signed document is uploaded as evidence. We are not building payments, escrow or settlement.

Nobody reaches this stage without being vetted by us first. We collect what the buyer intends to claim, how it operates and its approach to sustainability, and approve or decline. This is a condition of our funding and our main safeguard against greenwashing.

8. The transaction record and the rules that must hold

Every step is written to a permanent record: listed, offered, interest expressed, terms proposed, agreed, credits issued, allocated, retired, cancelled. On the public version of that record the buyer appears as a label such as "Buyer 014" with its sector, country and size, unless it has chosen to be named for that deal.

Seven rules must hold whatever any screen does. They belong in the database as constraints, triggers and permissions, not in application code, because application code gets rewritten and the rules must survive that.

1. Committed volume for a project and period never exceeds what the project expects to issue, less the buffer.
2. No credit can be allocated, transferred or retired without a reference to the scheme's registry record.
3. Once retired or cancelled, a credit never changes state again.
4. The record is append-only. Nothing is edited or deleted. A mistake is corrected by a new entry that points at the wrong one, and the wrong one stays visible.
5. A buyer's identity is shown as a pseudonym unless that deal is flagged for disclosure.
6. No deal can be created for an organisation we have not approved.
7. No screen, query, export or chart adds unit volumes across different projects.

Rules 1 to 6 can be enforced in Postgres. Rule 7 cannot, so it is a review habit and a test.

Row-level security needs care. One buyer seeing another buyer's prices or terms is the failure we most need to avoid. Please review the policies table by table rather than relying on whatever a tool generates.

9. Practical constraints

Hosting and database in a named EU member state region such as Frankfurt, Paris or Dublin, not a generic "Europe" region, which may include London or Zurich.

Personal data sits in one table only, the user accounts. Everything else references organisations by ID. A person must be deletable without breaking the permanent record; that is how the right to erasure and an append-only record coexist.

Project pages server-rendered and fast. Basic usage analytics from day one, self-hosted or EU-hosted, no third-party trackers. English first, German second, so a translation library from the first commit. Every page carries the EU emblem, the co-funding line and the disclaimer.

Plain, document-like design. One typeface, one accent colour, no stock nature photography, no marketing language. Every figure on screen carries its source and date. The test: a finance analyst reads a project page in ten minutes and knows what is being sold, where, on what evidence, with what claim rights and on what terms.

10. What we build first

The first release, which we want live by the end of October, is the public side plus a way in: the projects index with the catchment map, a full page for each pilot project with its idea note and design document, registration of a buyer's own sites so distances can be shown, the vetting questionnaire, the Express interest button, and the public record showing interest events.

Then: the private deal room, the three deal shapes, issuance and retirement records, investor data, exports.